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The Perpetual Nature of Plot: Telling a Story in Three Acts

The history of the three-act structure (did Aristotle *really* say that?) and how to use it to plot a book or series; plus, a look at its many variations.

by [The Campfire Team](#)



Aristotle
Poetics

A new translation by Anthony Kenny

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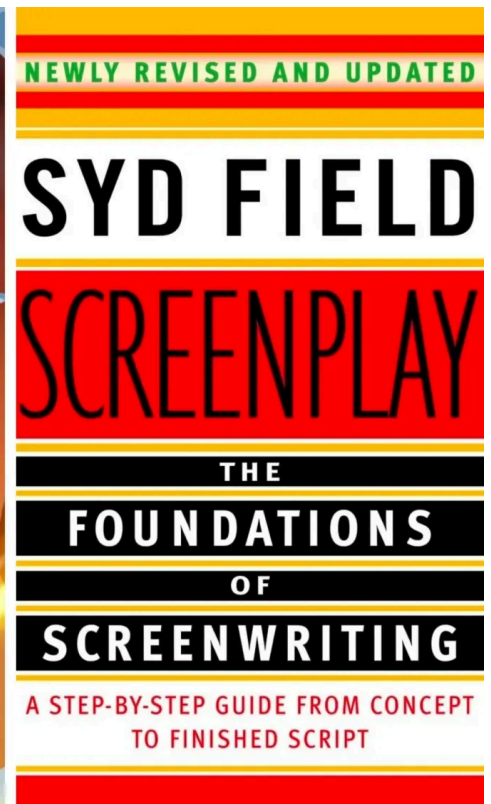


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If you're going to have just one [narrative structure](#) in your writer's toolkit, it probably be the **three-act structure**.

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The Campfire Team

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classics like Henrik Ibsen's *A Doll's House* and Jane Austen's *Pride and Prejudice* to blockbuster franchises like *Rocky Balboa* and *Star Wars*.

But what is it about the three-act structure that works so well? And how can you harness its powers to write your very own masterpiece? Let's take a look.

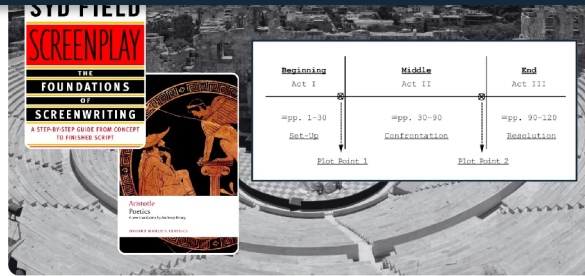
What is the Three-Act Structure?

The three-act story structure is one of our most popular narrative frameworks, with roots extending deep into the annals of literary history. Its enduring appeal can be attributed to one simple fact: reliability.

Put simply, three-act stories just work. They are so enjoyable to read/watch because they mimic the structure of stories we tell each other in real life, with a clear beginning, middle, and end.

To sum it up, we get the setup in Act One, the confrontation in Act Two, and the resolution in Act Three.

This structure not only charts the progression of your character arcs but also escalates your plot toward the climax to ensure a complete and satisfying resolution by the story's end.



Syd Field's model of the three-act structure, presented in his 1979 book, *Screenplay*, was inspired by Aristotle's ancient treatise, *Poetics*. Background image: Odeon of Herodes Atticus photographed by [Tom D'Arby](#) / Pexels.

Origins of the Three-Act Structure

Though he did not explicitly create the method, Aristotle sowed the seeds of the three-act structure in his 4th-century BCE work, *Poetics*, where he famously wrote: "A whole [story] is what has a **beginning** and **middle** and **end**."

The old philosopher believed that stories were a chain of cause and effect, where each event propels the next before finally culminating in a big conclusion.

In 1979, author Syd Field reconceptualized the three-act structure for modern screenwriting in his book *Screenplay*, substituting the terms **setup**, **confrontation**, and **resolution** in place of beginning, middle, and end.

Field referred to this as *the paradigm*, stating that it's the essential **foundation of dramatic structure**. Though the terminology varies—some prefer **setup**, **build**, and **payoff**—the core principles of this storytelling blueprint remain unchanged.

(**setup, confrontation, and resolution**) are the dramatic *context* placed within the structure (*Screenplay*, pg. 192). Field notes that each component of the three-act structure must end with a Plot Point to drive the story forward, which we refer to as Turning Points below.

Three-Act Story Structure Breakdown

The three-act structure has been picked apart and put back together so many times and in so many different ways but...**it all breaks down to a few core pieces of story structure:** beginning stuff that leads to a major plot point, middle stuff that leads to another major plot point, and the end stuff to bring it all to a close.

Each act of the structure as presented below contains three major plot points. Think of them as miniature, self-contained versions of the three-act structure nested within the overarching form.

- **Act One (Setup):** Exposition, Inciting Incident, First Turning Point
- **Act Two (Conflict):** Rising Action, Midpoint, Second Turning Point
- **Act Three (Resolution):** Buildup, Story Climax, Resolution

Innumerable stories follow the three-act structure, but for the sake of this breakdown, we will use the early 2000s hit animated series, *Avatar: The Last Airbender* as a unique example that fits

story in *ATLA* that plays out over the course of three seasons, likening each season to an act.

You heard it here first: Spoilers ahead!



The three stages of Aang's journey to mastering the four elements and fighting Fire Lord Ozai mirror the three-act structure of Setup, Conflict, and Resolution. Images: ©Nickelodeon Animation Studio.

Act One: Setup

- **Exposition:** This initial phase introduces the protagonist, setting, and key relationships.
- **Inciting Incident:** The inciting incident is a pivotal event that propels the protagonist into the main action of the story.
- **First Turning Point:** Marking the end of Act One, this turning point decisively commits the protagonist to their journey.

I don't know many more excellent, expository setups than *ATLA*'s famous opening, spoken by Katara, one of the show's main characters (the following is the abbreviated version):

everything changed when the Fire Nation attacked. Only the Avatar, master of all four elements, could stop them, but when the world needed him most, he vanished. A hundred years passed and my brother and I discovered the new Avatar, an airbender named Aang. And although his airbending skills are great, he has a lot to learn before he's ready to save anyone. But I believe Aang can save the world."

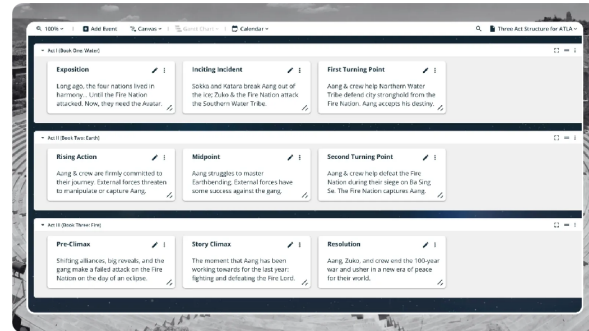
After Katara and Sokka find Aang and Appa in the ice and bring them back to their village, the Fire Nation attacks. Aang, who has been frozen in time for 100 years, is confronted with the realization that he *must* step into and own his role as the Avatar—the very survival of the world and everyone in it depends on him.

A large part of Aang's journey is having to overcome his feelings of doubt. He's only a kid, after all. Much of the first season (*Book One: Water*) shows us Aang's inward journey to accept himself and what he's capable of, culminating in the season finale. Here, Aang combines his Avatar abilities with the incredible, raw elemental power of the Ocean Spirit to help defend the Northern Water Tribe's city stronghold against the Fire Nation army.



In *Story*, Robert McKee writes that the inciting incident *should* generally be the start of Act One. In other words, he seems to skip past exposition, positing that the inciting incident *is* exposition as well as the true first turning point that "opens the telling" [of the story] (pg. 221).

necessary for your story, that could manifest as a prologue or simply the first chapter, perhaps succeeded by a time jump.



Example of the three-act structure in Campfire's Timeline Module using *Avatar: The Last Airbender* (2007–09, ©Nickelodeon Animation Studio).

Act Two: Conflict

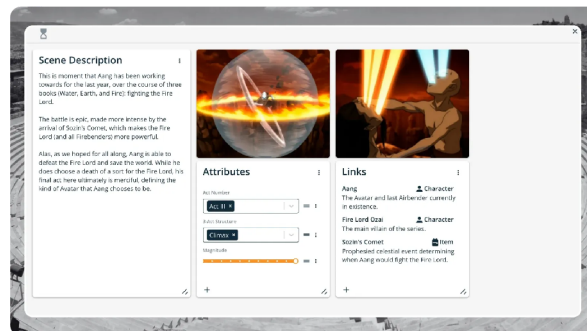
- **Rising Action:** The rising action ramps up the stakes and deepens the protagonist's challenges and conflicts.
- **Midpoint:** The midpoint injects a significant twist or revelation that changes the story's direction.
- **Second Turning Point:** This turning point dramatically increases the tension and paves the way for the climax.

In the second season (*Book Two: Earth*), Aang continues his journey to master the four elements with the help of his friends, now with the addition of Toph, his Earthbending teacher. Together, they all face new foes who seek to manipulate or capture the Avatar for various means.

During the halfway point of this season, everyone in the crew is at their lowest—

the Fire Lord sooner than thought, Aang's beloved sky bison, Appa, is kidnapped, and finally, the Fire Nation has a powerful network of spies operating in the Earth Kingdom to help take Team Avatar all down.

By the end of the season, Aang has overcome his mental block in mastering Earthbending, and the crew overcomes the successive challenges Book Two threw at them just in time to help save the Earth Kingdom as the Fire Nation lays siege to the formidable city, Ba Sing Se.



Act III: Climax for *Avatar: The Last Airbender* (2007-09, ©Nickelodeon Animation Studio), shown in an event card in Campfire's Timeline Module.

Act Three: Resolution

- **Pre-Climax/Buildup:** The pre-climax (also called the Buildup) is the moment right before the climax, where the tension and anticipation are at their highest.
- **Climax:** The climax is the story's most intense moment, the confrontation or event all the action has been building towards.
- **Denouement/Resolution:** The denouement ties up the narrative's

In the final season (*Book Three: Fire*), alliances shift, major information is revealed to the characters *and* the audience, and Aang hits one of the lowest points we've seen him at in his journey.

The Aang gang tries to seize an opportunity to attack the Fire Lord ahead of the planned time when they learn that an eclipse will black out the Sun, thereby muting the Firebender's powers. But of course, it goes awry, leading us to the inevitable climax we've been waiting for since Act One: Aang must fight and defeat the Fire Lord one-on-one.

Aang is successful in this endeavor—we get our payoff—and now, he has not only successfully mastered all four elements, but he's fully *become* the Avatar. Better yet, he's become the version of the Avatar that *he* chooses to be and be defined as. The 100-year war ends, the world is saved, and peace is had at last.



When you're ready to try out the three-act structure, Syd Field recommends starting with writing out your beginning, first turning point, second turning point, and ending—these are the most important plot points you'll draft for your story.

A Note on Pacing

Anyone who's ever talked about the three-act method agrees that a story needs to maintain a certain momentum to keep an audience engaged, and acts of

The consensus seems to be that the first and last acts should be the shortest, with the middle act being the longest. To quantify it, aim to have Acts One and Three take up ~25% of your story, each, and for Act Two to take up the remaining 50%—though, exact pacing may vary in your story.

Variations of the Three-Act Structure

Not every story lends itself to the three-act structure's format as presented above. Fortunately, there are several variations that writers can play with.

Robert McKee's Take On the Three-Act Structure

Another proponent of the three-act structure, Robert McKee added his own flair to the method, outlined in his book [*Story*](#) (originally published in 1997).

In it, he writes that **the three-act structure should have four essential parts, or turning points:** the inciting incident and the climaxes following Acts One, Two, and Three. The inciting incident and the first act climax, of course, should occur within the first act. McKee's version has the story beginning with the inciting action—the inciting incident turning point acts as the "opening of the telling." This technique is otherwise known as [*in media res*](#).

some stories have different requirements.

Your inciting incident may effectively be the first act's climax. In such cases where this happens, he makes a case for starting your story with a subplot as the opening: "Story must be told to hold the audience while it waits for a late-arriving Central Plot to ripen."

He also notes that to avoid the dreaded "sagging middle," all one needs to do is throw in a subplot (or a few) or add more acts—in other words, add more *conflict* to your story. Seems simple enough, right?

While that remains to be seen, remember this: All great [subplots serve best when they complement the story](#) at large. The same goes for additional Acts.

27 Chapter Method: Setup, Conflict, Resolution

[The 27 Chapter Method](#) also divides the narrative into three distinct acts—Setup, Conflict, and Resolution—but each one comprises nine chapters. It's essentially the three-act structure broken down into bite-sized pieces, giving writers a clear and specific way to outline their stories.

Unlike the broader strokes of the three-act structure, this approach ensures that

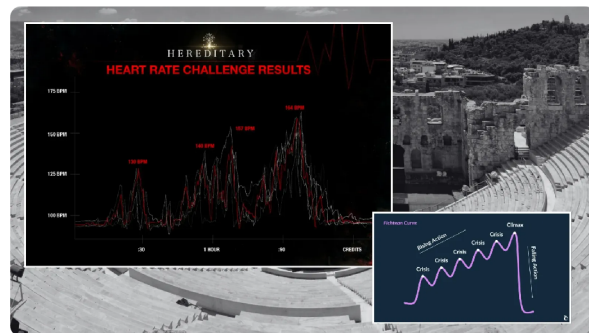
incremental tension and stakes escalation, with mini-cycles of setup, conflict, and resolution that keep readers engaged on a page-to-page basis.

Fichtean Curve: Rising Action, Climax, Resolution

Prefer to jump straight into the deep end?

[The Fichtean Curve](#) is a propulsive narrative structure that thrives on immediate action and sustained suspense. Eschewing the traditional three-act structure, which eases into the plot, the Fichtean Curve thrusts characters into escalating crises right from the outset.

It's the most visually literal iteration of the three-act structure.



The Fichtean Curve in action: these [heart rate readings](#) from *Hereditary* audience members near-perfectly mirror the curve.

This relentless progression of challenges, each more intense than the last, culminates in a climax where all conflicts and tensions peak. Particularly suited for the action, thriller, and horror genres, the Fichtean Curve crafts a narrative rollercoaster, keeping audiences on the edge of their seats.

Initiation, Return

[The Hero's Journey](#) expands on the traditional three-act structure by dividing the narrative into three phases:

Departure, where the hero is called to adventure; **Initiation**, where they venture into the unknown and face tasks or trials; and **Return**, where they come back from their journey changed.

Rocky could arguably be seen as an example of the Hero's Journey, but the Initiation phase generally involves crossing a threshold into a completely different world (sometimes literally). For this reason, the structure lends itself best to [epic fantasies](#), sci-fi adventures, and anything quest-related.

Save the Cat: Exposition, New World, Transformation

Are you even a screenwriter if you haven't studied [Save the Cat](#)? Blake Snyder's [seminal book](#) refines the three-act structure into a more detailed blueprint for screenwriting. The three stages are as follows:

1. **Act One:** Introduces the protagonist in their ordinary world and establishes a connection with the audience through a "[save the cat](#)" moment that showcases their likability.
2. **Act Two:** The "new world" phase sees the hero thrust into unfamiliar circumstances, challenging them to adapt and grow.

where the protagonist undergoes significant growth.

This structure is ideal for character-driven stories, as it ensures the audience forms a strong emotional connection with the protagonist.

Three-Act Structure Pros & Cons

The three-act structure has a nebulous history, and just like any other plot method, it's not perfect. Those who dislike the three-act structure do so with great passion, but those who champion it, find it to be the ultimate foundation of storytelling.

Pros of the Three-Act Structure

- **It gives story form:** The three-act structure is the oldest trick in a writer's bag. It's *the* starting place for all dramatic narratives, no matter how different each result may look. Every story has a beginning, middle, and end—even those that appear to lack a plot. When in doubt, begin with Act One.
- **It's essential:** Robert McKee thinks that without a third act, a story lacks rhythm. He even goes as far as to say that "the three-act design is the minimum" place to start when composing your story. It's not enough to say that something happened and this other thing happened because of it, end of story. Why does it all

- **It's flexible:** Below, we'll note a few cons of this method that some would argue are, in fact, pros. That the method is "vague" or "reductive" means that an author has greater flexibility to work within it and more clearly lay out their story. This is especially useful for stories that are longer and more complex than the average.

Cons of the Three-Act Structure

- **It's vague:** One of the largest criticisms of the three-act structure is that it's not very useful. *Your story should have a beginning, middle, and end...* Okay, but then what? And how long should each act be? And what should go in those acts? So on and so forth.
- **It's outdated:** Following the above line of thought, another argues that the three-act structure is old news. Everyone likes to point to Aristotle who lived thousands of years ago—thousands of years before modern storytelling took hold. In other words, we're not all trying to write ancient Greek dramas here.
- **It's reductive:** Finally, some feel the three-act structure reduces story to action, thereby putting too much focus on an element that only partly makes up a story. There is more to the craft of story-making, and forcing a story into three (or more) acts can feel arbitrary.

a method resonates with you, study it and test it out; if it works, great—if it doesn't, that's okay, too! The more you learn about and practice it, the greater muscle for and understanding of it you'll develop regardless.

Going Beyond Three Acts

As we noted above, even McKee said the three-act structure is *the minimum*. If you're looking for something more for your story, check out these four- and five-act structures.

Three-Act Structure vs. Four-Act Structures

Four-act structures are rather unique—they plot to their own beat, quite literally. Unlike the three- or five-act structures, the four-act structure redefines the basic elements of a story to make something that feels new and different; and more importantly, to form a structure that fits specific kinds of stories.

Here are a few notable examples of four-act structures.

- **Romancing the Beat**: Breaks down romance narratives into four key parts—the setup, falling in love, retreating from love, and fighting for love.
- **Kishōtenketsu**: A non-conflict-based plot structure common in Eastern Asian storytelling, comprising an introduction, development, twist, and reconciliation.

structure, some interpretations of Aristotle's work point to [several more acts](#).

Three-Act Structure vs. Five-Act Structures

Five-act structures have a long history to match the three-act structure: Originally presented by the Romans way back when (probably as part of their never-ending quest to one-up the Greeks), the five-act structure was used throughout the ages until the three-act structure regained popularity in the late 20th century.

The greatest difference between these two story structures is the placement of significant plot events. Where the three-act structure would just fit the five parts of a five-act structure into its three acts, the five-act structure makes them each the star of their own act. Here are a few popular five-act structures.

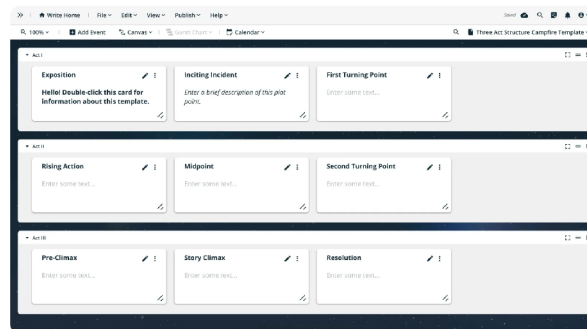
- **Five-Act Structure:** A formal plot structure that divides the story into exposition, rising action, climax, falling action, and denouement—a bell curve of drama, if you will.
- **Freytag's Pyramid:** Expands on the five-act structure with a focus on the climax's placement at the pyramid's peak. This structure also inevitably ends in tragedy.
- **Story Grid:** Sean Coyne's method divides the narrative into five parts—the inciting incident, turning point, crisis, climax, and resolution.

famous authors to consistently use a five-act structure in their work was the English playwright, William Shakespeare.

Act-based story structures can go up to six, seven, eight, or more. But the more acts you have, the more conflict you'll have to resolve, so take care to include only as many as you need for your story and cut out everything else.

Three-Act Structure Campfire Template

The Timeline Module in Campfire offers a versatile canvas to plot out each basic component of your story while featuring nested "notebooks."



A blank template for the three-act structure in Campfire's Timeline Module.

Simply double-click on each event card in your timeline to open up a canvas specific to that card. This allows you to look at your plot at the highest level, while also adding as much detail for each plot element as needed!

Template

Find a **template for the three-act structure** readymade for you in Campfire's Timeline Module.

To load a template in your project, click the **View** tab while in the Timeline Module, select "Manage Templates," then select from the options available or save your own!

Templates are editable, so once you load it up, make it your own! See our dedicated tutorial to learn more about [how to use the Timeline Module](#).

If you're new to Campfire, it's free to get started and give the platform a go. We'll make plotting your story as easy as 1, 2, 3



Start Plotting

The Final Act: Reflecting on the Three-Act Structure

The three-act story structure is the eldritch god of narrative frameworks for a reason. Its simplicity, versatility, and reliability offer a proven blueprint for storytelling across any genre.

By understanding and applying its core principles, writers can structure their

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I think the criticism for it being vague is probably one of its strengths. It gives you wiggle room.



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